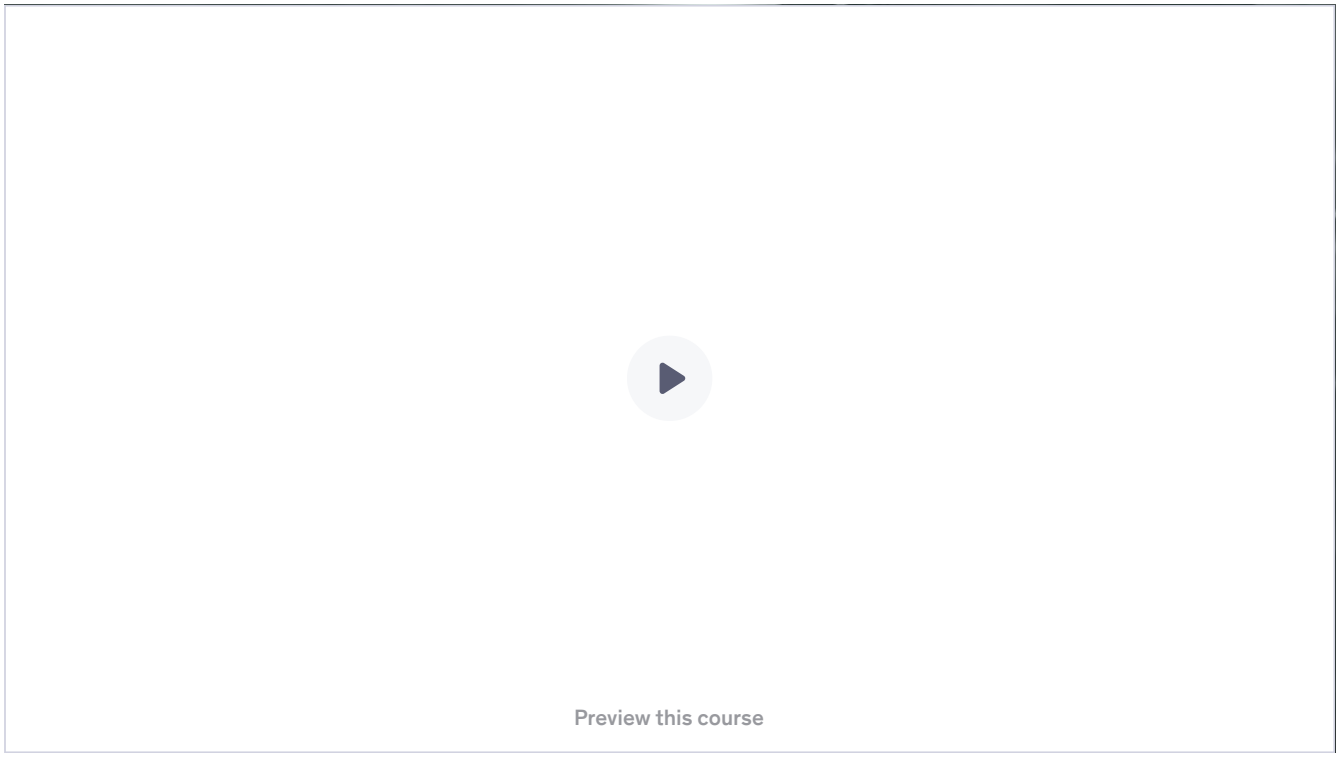
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Music > Music Production > Synthesizer



Synthesis and Sound Design: The Complete Beginner's Guide

A comprehensive guide to using any synthesiser to design your own unique sounds for music production

Bestseller 4.5 ★★★★½ (536 ratings) 2,894 students

Created by Steve Lydford

Last updated 8/2022 English English [Auto],

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What you'll learn

- Gain a deep understanding of the fundamental building blocks of synthesiser design.
- Use oscillators, envelopes, filters, LFOs and effects to create the ideal sounds for your compositions.
- Take the knowledge gained in this course and quickly be able to get the sound you want from ANY synthesiser.
- Apply your new knowledge by creating unique sounding instruments such as leads, keys, pads, basses, plucks, drums and cymbals.
- Be able to choose the right wave shapes, filters, modulators and effects by understanding exactly how every part of the synthesiser will affect your sound.

Explore related topics

Synthesizer | Sound Design | Music Production | Music

This course includes:

- 6.5 hours on-demand video
- 2 articles
- 3 downloadable resources
- Access on mobile and TV
- Full lifetime access
- Closed captions
- Certificate of completion

Course content

11 sections • 59 lectures • 6h 25m total length

Expand all sections

Introduction 4 lectures • 9min

Introduction	Preview	2:07
Getting the most from the course		1:41
Getting the Vital synth		3:18
Initial setup of Vital		2:13

How Synthesisers Work 3 lectures • 5min

Oscillators (VCOs) 9 lectures • 56min

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Filters (VCFs)	6 lectures • 37min
Low Frequency Oscillators (LFOs)	8 lectures • 44min
Effects	10 lectures • 28min
Wrapping Up	1 lecture • 5min
Sound Design	9 lectures • 1hr 49min

1 more section

Requirements

- No previous knowledge of synths or sound design is necessary, but access to a computer will enable you to follow along. The main synth used for teaching on the course (Vital) is available as a free download and will run on most modern Windows, Mac or Linux machines.

Description

In this course, we look in *quite some detail* at all the common elements of sound design using synthesisers. Whether you are brand new to synthesis, or an experienced sound designer, beatmaker or producer, this course will help you to really **understand how to construct exactly the sound you are looking** for for your mix.

With more than **six hours of video** split across over fifty lectures, you will find detailed descriptions and demonstrations of:

- Synthesiser architecture and how the different elements work together.
- Why the various wave shapes generated by oscillators create a different sound, and how to use them in combination.
- How to use ADSR envelopes to modulate the volume of your sound over time.
- The different types of filters commonly used and how to apply them to **create the perfect tone**.
- How to **add movement and depth to your sounds**.
- How to add effects such as chorus, distortion, delay and reverb to **make your sounds more interesting**.

Once you have finished these comprehensive sections and gained a *deep understanding* of exactly how every individual element of a synthesizer affects the sounds we are creating, we will use this knowledge to build several new sounds from scratch, including:

- Sub-bass
- Plucked bass
- Atmospheric and ethereal pads
- Leads
- Percussion, including hi-hats, kick drums, and snares
- Piano-like keys

We'll be using the free Vital synth throughout the course so you can follow along, but towards the end we'll spend some time looking at other synthesisers and see how to apply what you've learned to **quickly get to grips with *ANY* synth and know exactly how to use it to get the sounds you need** for your compositions.

Thank you for taking a moment to check out my course. **Click the enrol button above to join in and**

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Who this course is for:

- Beginner and experienced sound designers and music producers who want to really understand how to use their synthesizer to create their own unique, custom sounds

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Students also bought



Sound Design in 90 Minutes: Fast-Track Guide to Synthesizers

Premium 4.6 ★ 264 2 hours Updated: 12/2025

$15.99 ~~$19.99~~



Synthesis in Music & Sound Production

Premium 4.9 ★ 1,137 7.5 hours Updated: 12/2025

$15.99 ~~$19.99~~



Sound Design 102: Using Synthesis for Music Production

4.6 ★ 5,987 3 hours Updated: 11/2025

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Synth and Sound Design Basics for Beginners

4.5 ★ 122 7 hours Updated: 5/2026

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Sound Design for Music Composition

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How to Become a Synth Runner [Arturia Pigments]

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A comprehensive guide to using any synthesiser to design your own unique sounds for music production

Steve Lydford

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Ultimate Sound Design: Mastering Sound Design

Master sound design for music production, game audio development, film scoring, composition, and more!

J. Anthony Allen

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Mikael Baggström

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Instructor

Steve Lydford

Steve Lydford



★ 4.6 Instructor Rating

679 Reviews

3,530 Students

4 Courses

Steve is a sound designer, software engineer and author with over two decades of professional experience. He is an experienced teacher and has taught numerous courses both online and in-person.

He lives with his family in a remote farmhouse in mid-Wales, UK, where he doesn't have to worry about soundproofing or neighbours!

★ 4.5 course rating • 536 ratings

Nick

★★★★★ 17 days ago

Great primer to synthesizers. Took the overwhelm of all the functionality and simplified it to its essence allowing me to navigate different synths with much more confidence. Loved that Steve not only went into the basics of synths but also showed how to create basic sounds as a starting point like Kick, Snare, Bass, Piano, Pad, etc! For me, the value and knowledge was totally worth the time and price!

Helpful?

Tom

★★★★☆ 1 month ago

Accessible, material is repeated enough, Steve has a pleasant voice, he sticks to the basics

Helpful?

Johan

★★★★★ 4 months ago

This course was an absolute blast from start to finish. I enjoyed every single section—and that doesn't happen often with online courses! The instructor really knows his stuff and explains everything in a way that actually makes sense (which is rare when it comes to sound design…). He doesn't just show what to do, but also why you're doing it—which made a huge difference for me.…

Helpful?

Tyrone

★★★★★ 4 months ago

This course was perfect for me. I now fully understand the bass of synthesis which will allow me to move away from presets and start modifying parameters to get the sound I actually want

Helpful?

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More Courses by Steve Lydford



Make Music with Code: Complete Guide to Coding with Sonic Pi

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